

Tofu kebabs with cucumber-yogurt sauce

You'll need 4 wooden skewers for this recipe. Cut them, if necessary, to fit into a large skillet, leaving an inch [2.5cm] on each end to grab hold of. The recipe below cooks them easily in a large cast-iron skillet on top of the stove. If you prefer to grill the kebabs, soak the **skewers** in a bowl of water for at least half an hour to prevent burning. The tofu is vastly tastier if marinated overnight, so plan accordingly.

1 pound extra-firm tofu, pressed for 1 hour to remove excess water [500g]

½ teaspoon caraway seeds

1 teaspoon fenugreek

¼ cup plain yogurt, preferably organic [60ml]

2 tablespoons olive oil

2 tablespoons fresh lemon juice

2 teaspoons tamarind paste

2 tablespoons minced cilantro

2 garlic cloves, minced

1 teaspoon powdered mustard

½ teaspoon turmeric

3 splashes of Tabasco sauce

1 tablespoon unrefined cane sugar

2 tablespoons vegetable oil

Cucumber-Yogurt Sauce (recipe follows)

1. **Cut** the tofu into 1-inch [2.5-cm] cubes. Place in a large sealable plastic bag.
2. In a spice grinder, finely grind the caraway and fenugreek. **Turn** into a medium bowl. Add the yogurt, olive oil, lemon juice, tamarind paste, cilantro, garlic, sugar, mustard, turmeric, and Tabasco. Whisk to blend well.
3. Pour the yogurt marinade into the bag with the tofu. Make sure the cubes are well coated. **Press** out any extra air, seal, and refrigerate overnight.
4. Remove the tofu, reserving the marinade. **Skewer** 4 cubes onto each wooden skewer, lining them up so that they lie flat. Heat 1 tablespoon of the vegetable oil in

a large cast-iron skillet over medium-high heat. When very hot, fry 2 skewers at a time, turning, for 20 to 30 seconds on each of 4 sides, until crisp and browned all over. You should be able to grab the ends of the skewers to turn them. If you can't, use tongs. Repeat with another tablespoon of the oil and 2 more skewers.

5. **Serve** the warm kebabs with the cool cucumber-yogurt sauce on the side.

MAKES 4 SKEWERS

note This recipe serves 4 as an appetizer or 2 as a main dish.

Cucumber-yogurt sauce

1 large cucumber	1 cup plain yogurt, preferably organic [250ml]
2 tablespoons minced cilantro	¼ teaspoon salt
2 tablespoons finely diced red onion	⅛ teaspoon freshly ground pepper
2 garlic cloves, minced	
1 fresh serrano or jalapeño pepper, seeded and minced (optional)	

1. **Peel** the cucumber. Cut it lengthwise in half and scoop out the seeds. Grate the cucumber on the large holes of a box grater.
2. In a medium bowl, **combine** the cucumber with all the remaining ingredients. Mix well. Cover and refrigerate for at least 30 minutes before serving.

MAKES ABOUT 2 CUPS [500ML]